
IMESI

International Mutual Economic Security Instrument

Frequently Asked Questions for Ministers

Version 10.0

March 2026

40 Questions and Answers for Senior Government Officials

REFERENCE ARCHITECTURE — FOR OPEN CIRCULATION

I. WHAT IMESI IS

1. What is IMESI in one sentence?

IMESI is a modular mutual economic security insurance mechanism that protects member states against economic coercion—the use of trade, investment, or financial measures by one state to compel sovereign policy changes in another.

Reference: Executive Summary; Section 1.0E

2. How is IMESI different from a trade bloc or military alliance?

IMESI is neither. It does not set common tariffs, require foreign-policy coordination, or create mutual defence obligations. Even where coercion coincides with armed-force threats, IMESI remains strictly an economic stabilisation mechanism—nothing may be interpreted as a mutual defence pact or authorisation for force. Members maintain fully independent trade policies, bilateral relationships, and alliance memberships. A Regulatory Sovereignty Firewall ensures IMESI cannot prescribe or harmonise domestic regulation.

Reference: Philosophical Preamble; Sections 1.0D, 1.0E, 1.5B

3. Is IMESI directed against any specific country?

No. The Universal Applicability Principle makes explicit that IMESI applies equally to economic coercion from any source, including by its own members. No state is named in the text. Intra-member coercion is assessed under identical standards. No state is exempt from scrutiny and no state is presumptively targeted.

Reference: Section 2.0A; Non-Targeting Clause

4. What concrete benefits does membership deliver in peacetime—before any crisis?

From Month 1, members receive: joint procurement savings of 10–18% on strategic inputs; IEWC early-warning intelligence (including AI-driven regulatory pattern tracking) identifying threats 30–90 days before escalation; SFI settlement and swap-line access (including CBDC-ready channels); Resilience Fund eligibility; supply-chain rerouting assistance; Economic Entanglement Index exposure alerts; and Coercion Risk Dashboard signalling credible collective backing. The Pre-Activated Core provides intelligence sharing, procurement pilots, and risk dashboards from day one—before any case is activated.

Reference: Executive Summary; Section 10A.2D; Section 8.16

II. SOVEREIGNTY AND PARLIAMENTARY CONTROL

5. Does IMESI override national parliaments?

No. The Democratic Override (Section 1.0A) is non-derogable: no IMESI body may directly impose measures within any member's jurisdiction. All measures require implementation through existing constitutional processes. Any parliament may reject any measure at any time. Parliamentary Readiness Protocols are available as optional fast-track templates—not obligations.

Reference: Sections 1.0A, 1.0C; Annex 5A

6. What if a proposed response is too costly for my country?

Multiple safeguards: packages exceeding 0.5% GDP require affirmative parliamentary vote; above 1% GDP, quarterly review. The Domestic Industry Safeguard (Section 7.4A) allows temporary adjustment for severe sectoral harm. The MOAR opt-out permits withdrawal from specific measures. The Managed Adjustment Option (Section 7.4B) allows confidential notification of reduced participation during domestic strain—with a defined cost adjustment but no presumption of bad faith. The Implementation Flexibility Menu (Section 5.0I) lets members choose from 5 channels (trade, procurement, financial-lite, regulatory, or pure stabilisation contribution).

Reference: Sections 1.0A, 5.0I, 7.4, 7.4A, 7.4B, 2.4A

7. Can my government participate selectively or even silently?

Yes. Selective Participation (Section 3.3B) allows case-by-case, measure-level choice. Silent Participation (Section 3.3C) allows contribution without public visibility. The Minimum Viable Implementation Layer (MVIL, Section 3.3D) limits binding obligations to Phase 0 plus a pre-defined Phase 1 menu—designed for cautious or low-capacity governments. The Non-Coordination Safe Harbour (Section 5.0H) confirms members may use their own domestic tools; identical tariffs or synchronised timing are not required.

Reference: Sections 3.3B, 3.3C, 3.3D, 5.0H

8. Can we leave IMESI if circumstances change?

Yes. Observers exit on 90-day notice. Higher-tier members have term-based commitments with renewal points. The Grand Review every six years provides full amendment authority. A mandatory 5-year independent performance audit (by non-member experts) gives sceptics a credible renewal checkpoint. Withdrawal does not affect the validity of prior decisions or remaining members' authority.

Reference: Article III; Sections 10A.5A, 10A.6

III. HOW ACTIVATION WORKS

9. What triggers an IMESI activation?

Two pathways. Targeted Economic Coercion requires all five Article II elements: an economic measure, documented policy linkage, a sovereign policy target, material economic harm, and absence of free choice. Systemic Disruption (GSD/SND) requires quantitative thresholds validated by IEWC and an independent panel. The Non-Use Guarantee (Section 1.4C) explicitly excludes standard MFN tariff adjustments, monetary policy, and uniform regulatory changes. Routine policy changes are separately excluded from GSD/SND triggers.

Reference: Article II, Section 2.1; Sections 1.4C, 1.4D

10. How fast does IMESI respond?

Think of three clocks. Hours: Track A automatic stabilisation (liquidity, swap-lines, rerouting) deploys within hours—no vote needed. Days: Phase 1 political decisions within 5–7 days, with a 72-hour Rapid Legitimacy Signal from an independent panel. Months: deep reviews at 90 days, Phase 2+ sunset at 120 days, case closure at 180 days. Standard Response Templates for common patterns (tariff shock, financial exclusion, chronic pressure) can further accelerate activation-to-response time.

Reference: How the Clock Works; Sections 5.0A, 5.0F, 5.0J

11. What does a Phase 1 response actually look like?

Trade, procurement, and regulatory measures at 15–30% intensity: coordinated tariff adjustments on selected imports from the coercing state, procurement shifts, and regulatory review of coerced-linked investments. Financial instruments excluded at Phase 1. Members choose from the Implementation Flexibility Menu (trade, procurement, financial-lite, regulatory, or pure stabilisation). Voluntary Pre-Committed Response Portfolios allow members to pre-deposit preferred configurations for faster activation.

Reference: Sections 5.0A, 5.0I, 5.0K; Section 8.10I

12. How does escalation work, and what prevents runaway measures?

Each phase requires a separate CC vote. The Cascade Circuit-Breaker limits simultaneous activations. A Tariff Escalation Ceiling with automatic freeze caps tariff levels. All Phase 2+ measures sunset at 120 days. Harmonised review cycles (30/90/180 days) force active decisions. For systemic economies, Enhanced Consultation provides 7 additional days plus a published Proportionality and Systemic Risk Note before the vote. De-escalation is the default.

Reference: Sections 5.0G, 5.2B, 5.3E, 5.4A, 5.11

13. What if coercion stops partway through?

De-escalation is automatic. Off-ramps at every stage: quiet consultation (days 3–5), mediation at any time, 30-day diplomatic window at the Day 45 review, full phase step-down. Crisis deviation allowance (Section 6.0B) ensures temporary domestic adjustments don't trigger breach. Resolution pathways allow face-saving partial compliance for durable settlements.

Reference: Sections 5.0D, 5.2A, 5.3G, 6.0B

14. What if harm is clear but we cannot identify the coercer?

The Provisional Activation mechanism (Section 5.0M) allows reversible Phase 0 measures and limited Phase 1 stabilisation when harm thresholds are met but attribution is uncertain. No tariffs, quotas, or long-term flow changes. Auto-expires at 30 days unless attribution is clarified. Intended solely to prevent systemic harm—not to assign responsibility or impose punitive measures.

Reference: Section 5.0M

IV. LEGAL COMPATIBILITY

15. Is IMESI compatible with WTO obligations?

Yes. Countermeasures are legally grounded in GATT Article XXI (security exceptions) and Article XX (general exceptions). The WTO Defence-in-Depth Protocol (Annex 1A.1) provides model legal reasoning for security exceptions, balance-of-payments safeguards, and systemic-risk mitigation rationales. The Secretariat maintains model WTO pleadings for five scenario types. A Compatibility Assessment is mandatory before Phase 2+.

Reference: Annex 1A; Annex 1A.1

16. Does membership conflict with existing FTAs or bilateral investment treaties?

No. IMESI is explicitly non-exclusive (Section 1.1A). No member must withdraw from or modify any existing agreement. The Open Architecture clause (Section 9.6A) allows non-members to join selected modules (supply-chain, procurement, early-warning) without full membership or alignment obligations.

Reference: Sections 1.1A, 9.6A; Annex 1B

17. How does IMESI interact with existing sanctions regimes?

IMESI does not require lifting, aligning, or modifying existing sanctions. It operates alongside existing regimes. IMESI intelligence may inform national sanctions decisions but cannot override them. Members with conflicting sanctions obligations may invoke Selective Participation (Section 3.3B) without penalty. IMESI is economic insurance, not a sanctions-coordination body.

Reference: Sections 3.3B, 7.4A

V. SAFEGUARDS AGAINST MISUSE

18. What stops IMESI from being activated against routine trade policy?

The Non-Use Guarantee explicitly excludes standard MFN tariff adjustments, central bank decisions, fiscal measures, and uniform regulatory changes. GSD/SND cannot be triggered solely by WTO-consistent, uniformly applied policies. Any member may challenge an activation via the IAC (7-day ruling). The Regulatory Sovereignty Firewall (Section 1.0D) ensures IMESI does not opine on the desirability of members' regulatory choices.

Reference: Sections 1.0D, 1.4C, 1.4D

19. What if a member files a bad-faith coercion claim?

Misuse Liability (Section 6.12) imposes penalties: 6-month voting suspension + 0.05% GDP penalty for first offence; tier downgrade + 12-month suspension for second. IEWC applies documented evidentiary standards—circumstantial evidence alone is insufficient. If the system gets it wrong, False Positive Compensation (Section 6.12A) provides remediation for both the affected state and good-faith implementing members.

Reference: Sections 6.12, 6.12A, 2.15

20. Who certifies coercion, and are they independent?

The IEWC certifies through 7-of-10 majority: 5 core rotating members (24-month terms), 3 affected-member seats (who recuse if they're the subject), and 2 independent experts appointed by the IAC. Automatic recusal for accused members. Published methodology, dissent publication, borderline cases auto-referred to external review. The RLSM Panel (3 independent experts) issues a 72-hour public Legitimacy Note. IEWC determinations now include a published methodological summary. Small-state IEWC members receive dedicated analyst support and a 10-day immersion programme.

Reference: Sections 1.6B, 1.6B.1, 4.2T, 4.2U, 4.2V

21. What prevents the biggest economies from dominating?

Supermajority thresholds (55–75%) mean no single economy controls outcomes. At least 2 IEWC + 2 IAC seats reserved for small states. Director-General appointment requires 70% + small-state support. No single-member veto principle (Section 4.1D). Quorum resilience ensures vacancies cannot paralyse operations. Budget continuity prevents funding hostage-taking. Multi-host distribution ensures no single country controls institutional infrastructure.

Reference: Sections 1.0B, 1.6B, 4.1A, 4.1C, 4.1D, 4.1E, 4.6G, 7.5, 8.0C

22. No single country can weaponise this—how?

No single country can trigger, block, or control certifications. No state sits on IEWC while accused. Certification requires 7-of-10 majority including 2 independent experts appointed by the IAC, not by governments. All decisions are applied under the Universal Applicability Principle and Non-Discrimination in Application safeguard—any member may request a public explanation of how criteria were applied in a given case.

Reference: Sections 2.0A, 4.1D, 4.1F

VI. FINANCIAL OBLIGATIONS

23. What does membership cost?

Contributions are GDP-proportional: G7-equivalent (~0.06–0.08% GDP/year), major economy (~0.04–0.06%), mid-size (~0.03–0.05%), small state (~0.01–0.02%), LDC (<0.01%). Hard annual cap: 0.25% of GDP including all emergency calls. A 10% Contingent Continuity Band ensures core operations survive any single member's contribution shortfall.

Reference: Annex 8A; Sections 8.0A, 8.0B

24. What is the target fund size?

For a 12-member coalition (~USD 45T GDP): ~USD 2.25–4.5B/year, 5-year target ~USD 11–22B. No single activation may draw >15% without 75% CC vote. Designed for 2 simultaneous medium cases + 1 small case within caps. Budget continuity ensures the previous year's budget continues automatically if no new budget is adopted.

Reference: Annex 8A; Sections 8.4E, 8.0C

25. What if the Fund runs low during a crisis?

Fund Solvency Safeguards (Section 8.4D) provide emergency capital calls. Coalition Capacity Insurance (Section 8.30) provides market-backstop capacity. The Multi-Crisis Stress Envelope models simultaneous scenarios. No member's total annual exposure may exceed 0.25% GDP.

Reference: Sections 8.4D, 8.4E, 8.30

VII. SMALL STATES AND DEVELOPING COUNTRIES

26. Why should a small state join?

Small states are most vulnerable to coercion and least able to resist alone. IMESI provides 17+ dedicated protections: Small States Collective Caucus with guaranteed institutional voice; 20% hard-reserve in the Resilience Fund; automatic first-activation presumption; Legal and Negotiation Support Unit; Non-Abandonment Clause; dedicated IEWC analyst support and immersion programme; Compliance Safe Harbour (60% threshold, not 70%); and MVIL light-touch participation mode.

Reference: Small-State Provisions; Sections 4.1A, 4.2S, 5.0B, 5.0C, 8.1A; Section 1.6B.1

27. Can a micro-state participate without binding obligations?

Yes. The Micro-State Participation Framework (Annex 22A) provides tailored arrangements with symbolic/low-cost substitute measures. The Founding Observer Track offers zero-risk entry. Micro-states may also enter through the Tariff Refugee Window during crises—zero obligations, full humanitarian access, 90 days.

Reference: Annex 22A; Sections 3.1A, 3.2C

VIII. PRIVATE SECTOR AND MARKET IMPACT

28. How does IMESI affect private businesses?

Four principles govern all firm obligations: proportionality (scales with phase and sector), predictability (pre-notified sectoral playbooks), due process (30-day notice + IAC appeal for Phase 2+), and non-punitive stance (firms complying with domestic law in good faith are not penalised). Phase 0–1: minimal obligations. Certified Transparent Operators receive MFN treatment. The IMESI Business Council offers a voluntary "Resilience Certified" supply-chain mark with preferred procurement eligibility. Firms can submit anonymised early-warning information and receive early rerouting access—"sensors and beneficiaries, not cannon fodder."

Reference: Sections 3.17, 9.8A, 9.8B

29. How does IMESI affect banks and financial institutions?

Phase 0–1: zero new bank obligations. Financial instruments activate only at Phase 2+ with separate 60% CC vote. Measures include SFI settlement fee adjustments and swap-line coordination—defensive only. Banks may opt out. Financial Impact Assessment published before deployment. SFI coverage extends to CBDC channels where technically feasible. All financial measures expire on case closure.

Reference: Sections 8.10G, 8.10I, 8.10+

30. Will IMESI disrupt consumers or cause inflation?

Safeguards built in: industry/labour consultation and published consumer price impact assessment before measures causing >USD 1B domestic impact or >5% price increases. Humanitarian Floor prohibits restrictions on food, medicine, and basic goods. The Corporate Execution Protocol (Annex 25) provides voluntary model playbooks for rerouting and supply continuity. Members are encouraged to integrate IMESI contingencies into existing national emergency planning.

Reference: Part C; Annex 25

IX. COALITION INTEGRITY

31. What if two members disagree on whether a third state is coercing?

Intra-coalition disagreements go to expedited dispute resolution (Section 6.9A). Both sides present views. IEWC and IAC maintain independence. Disagreement does not freeze stabilisation—Track A proceeds unless 70% vote to suspend. The objecting member may invoke Selective Participation to abstain from specific measures. Proceedings continue even if a party declines to participate (Section 6.9B).

Reference: Sections 6.9A, 6.9B

32. What if the coercing state is also an IMESI member?

Universal Applicability (Section 2.0A): identical standards apply. Automatic IEWC recusal. Symmetric Restraint for systemic economies (75% + independent panel). Higher bar for financial instruments (60% vote). IMESI maintains credibility as a rules-based system, not a club that never disciplines its own.

Reference: Sections 2.0A, 7.5

33. What if a major member tries to undermine IMESI from within?

Ten institutional resilience provisions: quorum resilience (vacancies cannot paralyse); no single-member veto; DG appointment protection (70% + small-state support); budget continuity; multi-host distribution; procedural continuity in absence; contingent funding band; withdrawal continuity; systemic non-implementation reporting; and anti-corruption provisions covering off-book inducements to fracture the coalition. The Transparency Ledger creates early awareness of IMESI-relevant bilateral negotiations.

Reference: Sections 4.1C–4.1F, 6.1(h), 6.4B, 6.11(d), 8.0B, 8.0C, 10A.6

X. FOUNDING THE COALITION**34. Who are the expected founding members?**

Illustrative: 10–12 states (EU core, UK, Canada, Japan, Australia, South Korea + Global South partners). Minimum Viable Coalition: as few as 6 Full Members at 15% global GDP. Any 3+ major economies plus 2 small states may call a Founding Conference. Systemic economies may act as Founding Sponsors by hosting institutions and making enhanced contributions—by separate arrangement, not hard-wired into the treaty.

Reference: Sections 3.1G, 10A.2B; Founding Roadmap

35. What is the fastest path to getting IMESI operational?

Path C (Regional Pilot): 5–8 willing states under a joint MoU, simplified scope (tariffs + basic liquidity), 18–24 months. No formal ratification. Pre-accession simulation exercises (Section 3.1H) build institutional capacity. Pilot participants convert to provisional accession and qualify for Founding Member status and First-Mover Protection.

Reference: Sections 3.1F, 3.1H; Pilot Scenario Proposal

36. Who moves first?

IMESI can move from concept to pilot if three willing major economies and two small states jointly task their sherpas—at a G7, OECD, or regional summit—to launch a 12–18 month pilot under simplified scope. Five governments, one joint communique, one MoU, one working group with a 12-month mandate. The question is not "is this ready?" The question is: "which five governments will pick up the phone?"

Reference: Founding Political Roadmap; Who Moves First

37. What advantages do founding members receive?

First-Mover Protection Package: 1.5x Fund access for 3 years; heightened severity presumption for coercion targeting founders; guaranteed IEWC/IAC seats for the first review cycle. First-Mover Protection Window: 10–15% of Fund reserved for founding members during pre-operational period with enhanced terms. Founding members shape governance, set precedents, and define operational culture.

Reference: Sections 3.1F, 8.9D

38. What is the minimum commitment to begin?

The Founding Observer Track: intelligence sharing, supply-chain cooperation, CC observation—zero obligations, zero financial commitments, exit on 90 days' notice. A government can observe, evaluate, and decide with full information before committing.

Reference: Section 3.2C

39. Does the system really need 230 pages?

Ministers are not required to master the full technical detail. IMESI's operational logic rests on three simple anchors: three clocks (hours/days/months), three phases (0/1/2), and four standard time-bands. Everything else is internal plumbing for consistency, legal defensibility, and small-state protection—it can be delegated to technical officials without diminishing political control.

Reference: Operational Simplicity Principle

40. What are the next steps for a minister considering IMESI?

Three actions: (1) designate a senior official for informal scoping consultations at the next ministerial margins (G7, OECD, or WTO Ministerial); (2) request a technical briefing on the full IMESI v10.0 framework (230 pages, available for open circulation); and (3) consider whether your government would participate in a low-risk tabletop pilot exercise under Path C, requiring no binding commitments.

Reference: Founding Political Roadmap; Pilot Scenario Proposal

This FAQ summarises IMESI v10.0 (March 2026). The full framework text is available for open circulation and detailed review.